

Vincent Armentano

Doctoral Candidate — Economics Department — University of California San Diego

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics

Expected completion: June 2027

University of California San Diego

B.A. in Economics & International Affairs

2016

Northeastern University

Fields of Interest

Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics

References

Craig McIntosh (Co-Chair)	Tom Vogl (Co-Chair)	Paul Niehaus	Sara Lowes
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Job Market Paper

- “Crop Portfolio Diversification under Fixed Entry Costs: Evidence from a Cash Transfer in Mali”

The selection of crops farmers cultivate has long been recognized as a portfolio problem, but the literature currently measures the properties of a farmer’s portfolio with crop counts and Herfindahl variants that cannot capture the variance-covariance structure determining welfare-relevant risk. I apply Modern Portfolio Theory (MPT) to smallholder agriculture, constructing a covariance matrix of crop returns from a Malian panel and evaluating household portfolios relative to efficient frontiers. Three findings emerge. First, smallholders exhibit a positive size-diversification gradient where doubling cultivated area is associated with adding one crop type, consistent with a per-crop fixed cost. Second, exogenous cash grants relax the implied constraint through the extensive margin. The treated group expands cultivation by 15.5% of the control mean for crops at small baseline shares, with little movement on high-share crops, and the smallest-farm quintile fails to clear the threshold even with the grant. Third, the resulting reallocation reduces the standard deviation on portfolio returns per hectare while leaving expected profit per hectare unchanged, raising the Sharpe ratio and moving households closer to their community-specific efficient frontiers. An exercise making reasonable assumptions about risk aversion yields certainty-equivalent welfare gains of 17–27% of grant value from this movement in portfolio properties. With 59% of idiosyncratic income shocks passing through to consumption in this setting, liquidity-constrained households bear inefficiently high portfolio variance because the additional crops that would reduce risk lie behind a fixed-cost threshold they cannot clear — a hidden production cost of incomplete markets that crop counts and HHI miss, but the MPT framework recovers.

Publications

- “Movin’ on up? The impacts of a large-scale housing lottery in Uruguay” *Journal of Public Economics*, Vol. 235, July 2024. With Craig McIntosh, Felipe Monestier, Rafael Piñeiro-Rodríguez, Fernando Rosenblatt and Guadalupe Tuñón.

We report on a large-scale urban resettlement program in Uruguay. Under the program, thousands of low- to middle-income households were randomly assigned over the course of seven years to ownership of apartments in new buildings in more central areas and received a subsidy averaging \$44,000 per household. We match applicants to comprehensive administrative data on employment, schooling, fertility, and voting over the decade after the move. We find that the program led to a small decline in fertility for women and a two-percentage-point increase in formal employment but did not affect school attendance. The relocation program did not result in transformative improvements in the lives of its beneficiaries, likely because of its minimum income requirements and the lack of strong spatial inequality in Uruguay.

Working Papers

- “How Poverty Fell”, with Paul Niehaus and Tom Vogl. NBER WP Available

The share of the global population living in extreme poverty fell dramatically from an estimated 36% in 1990 to 9% in 2015. We describe how this decline happened: the extent to which changes within as opposed to between cohorts contributed to poverty declines, and the key changes in the lives of households as they transitioned out of (and into) poverty. We do so using cross-sectional and panel sources that are representative or near-representative of five countries that collectively accounted for 75% of global poverty decline between 1990 and 2015. The data show that overlapping birth cohorts experienced the decline of poverty together over time, such that poverty decline can be viewed as a primarily within-cohort phenomenon. Within cohorts, the data reveal substantial churn, casting the challenge of escaping poverty as a “slippery slope” more than a long-term trap. The data also illustrate a diversity of pathways out of poverty: sectoral transitions, migration, and changing occupational choices and female labor force participation can all account for some part of poverty reduction, but in all but a handful of cases, a majority of households exiting poverty did so without experiencing these changes.

- “Regulatory Risk and Firm Decision-making: Evidence from the Waters of the United States and US Farms”, with Philip G. Hoxie. Draft available on SSRN.

Federal regulatory changes often impose substantial costs on directly affected firms. This paper asks a more nuanced question: Does the regulatory process itself, including the threat of regulatory changes, also impose substantial costs? We leverage a proposed jurisdictional change to the Clean Water Act, which led to regulatory changes in some states and only regulatory risk in others, in tandem with variation in the share of cropland potentially affected by the jurisdictional change in each county. We estimate an exposure difference-in-differences design to measure the effects of regulatory exposure on the reservation price for farming, as measured by rents from the Conservation Reserve Program. Using a willingness-to-pay-style analysis, farms subject to regulatory risk experience costs that are about 60% as large as the costs associated with the regulatory change itself. Moreover, due to a provision in the Clean Water Act which exempts certain types of pollution that accompany “regular” farming, we see that the threat of future regulation acted as an incentive to expand cropland in advance of any changes. This eroded other policy goals, in this case establishing new farming practices at the expense of the preservation of certain types of conservation lands. A simple back of the envelope calculation suggests that after accounting for both regulatory risk and the direct cost of regulation, the Clean Water Rule had a total cost to farms of about \$2.9 Billion (2022 USD) annually.

Presentations

- DevPEC, 2026 (*Job Market Paper*)

Professional Service

Referee	Journal of Development Economics, Economic Development and Cultural Change
Conference Organizer	Southern California Graduate Conferences in Applied Economics, Graduate Student Research Seminar
Extracurricular support	Federal Reserve Challenge (Mentor), ECONected (Founder)

Honors and Awards

UC Office of the President, Global Food Initiative Fellow	2021-22
Summer Research Fellowship	2021
Summer Research Fellowship	2020

Relevant Professional Employment

Graduate Student Researcher	2020 - 2021, 2024
<i>Agricultural Technology Adoption Initiative</i>	

- Worked with CEGA and ATAI staff to harmonize data across 29 RCTs with an agricultural focus
- Helped design and implement a system to merge ATAI survey data with Google Earth Engine data about weather and environment
- Designed a digital portal where the data could be downloaded by the public — portal.atai-data.org

Senior Research Analyst

2017 - 2020

Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

- Performed regression analysis on a multi-armed agricultural RCT, exploring heterogeneity across rainfall distribution, gender, and soil dimensions using marginal effect analysis
- Utilized Causal Forest and Double Machine Learning algorithms to estimate heterogeneous treatment effects
- Wrote automated, one-touch Stata programs to perform: a Post-Double-Selection LASSO; marginal effects at desired points of an out-of-sample Rainfall Profits Surface; randomization inference on those marginal effects; and Bonferroni q-value adjustment on the resulting randomization-inference p-values
- Assisted with senior administrative research tasks, including managing stakeholders, hiring and overseeing the training process for new Research Analysts, and supervising multiple Undergraduate Research Analysts

Research Analyst

2016 - 2017

Innovations for Poverty Action

- Oversaw data collection of a 3,120 Household Sample RCT, performing data quality assurance checks
- Performed data cleaning on collected data in Stata software, examining outliers and summary stats
- Assisted in writing academic papers, project reports and policy memos on a variety of topics
- Participated in the design of survey questionnaire items and survey construction with SurveyCTO software

Teaching Experience, Teaching Assistant

ECON100C: Microeconomics C

Winter 2025

ECON100A: Microeconomics A

Fall 2024

ECON164: The Indian Economy

Spring 2024

ECON1: Principles of Microeconomics

Winter 2024

ECON100A: Microeconomics A

Fall 2023

ECON3: Principles of Macroeconomics

Winter 2022

ECON1: Principles of Microeconomics

Fall 2021

Other Information

Citizenship: United States

Skills: Stata, R, Python, QGIS, ArcGIS, Google Earth Engine & Claude

Non-academic interests: Astrophotography, Boardsports, Filmmaking & Milkshakes